CENTRE OF ATTENTION
Mahasamadhi of Sri Sathya Sai Baba in Prasanthi Nilayam



WITH PRASANTHI NILAYAM UNABLE TO EXPAND ITS OUTREACH, MADHUSUDAN HAS MANAGED TO **SHIFT FOCUS TO SATHYA SAI GRAMA**

He had given instructions to build a home on his last visit to Muddenahalli in 2009. So Anandam, a building atop a hillock with a spiral ramp leading up to it, was designed as his residence. On top of the building is a clock tower with a 153-feet statue of Shiva and another one of Nandi coming up next to it. Once Sai Baba died in 2011, Madhusudhan moved into the space he vacated.

THE RISE AND RISE OF MADHUSUDAN

Under his guidance, the Sathya Sai Grama has come into its own, attracting devotees and celebrities alike. Madhusudhan says he banks on two watchwords—Love and Service—about the power of affection and its manifestation in serving the needy, to carry forward Sai Baba's legacy. He calls the triple elixir of nutrition, education and healthcare as the prime areas of service. A year after Sai Baba's death, Madhusudan had a school opened in Kalaburagi, north Karnataka, followed by a paediatric cardiac care hospital at Nava Raipur Atal Nagar, Chhattisgarh. His mission has only evolved and grown ever since.

The pace at which things have moved under his watch has been astonishing, say his supporters. A 300-bed multi-speciality hospital, the Sri Sathya Sai Sarala Memorial Hospital, catering to the poor, came up on the Muddenahalli campus in 2018. The swanky hospital, built in the shape of a swastika, is currently the busiest place in Sathya Sai Grama with a long line of patients at the registration counter. "We see close to 1,000 outdoor patients daily," claims S.S. Bharath Kumar, head of projects. Their focus is mostly on congenital heart diseases in children, obstetrics and gynaecology. The 250 staffers include 70 doctors. Most of them stay on campus and their children study in the school there. Among them is Shagufta Ara, a nurse from Jammu & Kashmir, who was recognised as a Covid warrior during her stint at Srinagar's Jawaharlal Nehru Memorial Hospital where she attended to 100 newborns during the first wave of the pandemic in 2020. Later that year, during a visit to the Muddenahalli ashram to receive an award, she decided to quit her job at the Srinagar hospital and shift base along with her husband, two daughters and parents-in-law. Ara now handles the neonatal intensive care unit at the Sri Sathya Sai Sarala Memorial Hospital. "I was very impressed during our visit," she says.

Apart from the hospital, a block of apartments was also built for ashram residents and guests. Next in line was a 5,000-seat auditorium. Work on a sports stadium is going on, while a school for music and the performing arts is on the drawing board. Bhuvana Santhanam, CEO of global outreach at Sathya Sai Grama, makes it a point to emphasise that everything is free on campus. "Housing, food, electricity, water...the institution takes care of everything," she says. Like many others here, she too is an alumna of SSSIHL. Described by some as 'Madhusudan's right hand', Santhanam worked as a strategic brand and image management consultant for 20 years before she settled here in 2015.

Madhusudan is said to be involved in every aspect of the burgeoning organisation. He travels through the year for board meetings and site visits, conducting team reviews and developing strategies to expand his mission's footprint. Planning to strengthen the initiatives through collaborations, he has come up with the 3S model—a convergence of *samaja* (society), *sarkara* (government) and *samstha* (institution)—to implement a slew of services and achieve a larger impact with scale. To this end, he set up the Sai Global Federation of Foundations that brings together an international community of organisations. There are 35 registered trusts and foundations across 33 countries, including India, that implement the various projects.

As a result, Madhusudan now spearheads a global mission that has established institutes of education, healthcare, nutrition and spirituality in most of these countries. It runs six multi-speciality hospitals in India and three abroad that offer free healthcare. There are 37 educational institutions across 27 campuses and a university